



— FREE RESOURCE · GUIDE 4 OF 5

Essay 3 – Course Choice

Connecting your capability gap to a specific course, university and UK priority area, without ever naming a ranking.

ABOUT THE EXAMPLES.

All universities, professors, modules, institutions and statistics below are anonymised and reinvented versions of successful essays, changed to show technique. Yours must be real, current and verifiable.

THE LIVE QUESTION.

Explain your first choice of course and university only. Please relate your answer to one of the UK priority areas for Chevening:

- What is the specific priority area you wish to address?
- How will your chosen course equip you to address this theme in your home country?
- Why have you selected your particular university in the UK?
- How do you plan to immediately apply the knowledge or skills you will gain after your studies?

WORD LIMIT:

Minimum 100 / Maximum 300 words.

THE ARGUMENT IN FIVE STEPS.

What I already know → what I lack → why that gap matters → why this specific course closes it → how I will apply the capability immediately.

WORD PLAN AT 300 WORDS

Problem + priority area 70 · Course + modules 110 · University + faculty 60 · Immediate application 60

Part one: the priority area

Name one in Chevening's exact wording, in a full sentence:

- Promoting growth and prosperity
- Building resilience in a climate-vulnerable world
- Strengthening security and stability in a volatile world
- Supporting development for more inclusive and effective societies

Pick the area where your evidence is strongest. Stay inside it.

Part two: the capability gap is the hinge

Write this sentence before drafting:

“My experience has equipped me to do X, but I currently lack Y, which limits my ability to achieve Z.”

For every course feature you name, run the chain:

course feature → capability gained → gap addressed → future application in home country.

Part three: naming in this essay

Name the course exactly, two or three modules exactly, the research centre, two academics with their positions and what of theirs you will use, and any prior contact.

Name the national figure and then your own province or district (the zoom).

Part four: four reasons that score nothing

1. Rankings and reputation.
 2. Prospectus or marketing text.
 3. The city, landmarks, culture, London, or improving English.
 4. Vague course content (“a comprehensive curriculum”).
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Part five: writing it, paragraph by paragraph

Paragraph 1 — Priority area + diagnosis (~70 words)

Open with a diagnosis from your own work. Name the priority area in a full sentence. Give national figure + your province/district.

Paragraph 2 — Course and how it equips you (~110 words)

State existing capability + gap. Name two or three modules and what each lets you produce that you cannot produce now. Mention teaching/assessment if useful.

Paragraph 3 — Why this university (~60 words)

Two academics with positions and reasons. Research centre or partnership. Any prior contact. One clause on why the UK in professional terms.

Paragraph 4 — Immediate application after studies (~60 words)

Place + partner + action + way of knowing. First year only. Small, real, startable.

Part six: two full sample answers

All names, places and statistics are anonymised and reinvented. Do not copy.

Sample one — civil registration (299 words)

Fewer than half the children in Katiba Province hold a birth certificate, and without one they cannot sit national exams or later inherit land. Nationally coverage is 38 per cent; in Katiba it is 30. Four years of registration work has convinced me this is an administrative failure rather than a demand failure, and my priority area is supporting development for more inclusive and effective societies.

I can generate evidence but I have never designed an evaluation, which is why Kalima Registration Outreach cannot yet be costed for national rollout. The MSc Social Policy and Evaluation at Northgate University closes that gap directly. Its Impact Evaluation module covers the quasi-experimental designs our pilots have never had, and Public Service Design gives me frameworks to test whether a service reaches the people it was written for rather than counting forms processed. The dissertation route permits fieldwork, so I intend to evaluate the notification protocol against a matched comparison in Molo.

I chose Northgate for the Ashcombe Centre for Public Service Reform, which works with national registration authorities rather than only publishing about them. Professor Helen Aird's research on incentive design in frontline services addresses our exact constraint, that registrars are assessed on volume rather than coverage. Dr Marcus Oyelaran supervised the chapter I contributed to the Centre's 2025 volume on service access, and that correspondence showed me how far my methods fall short of his.

In my first year back I will replicate the outreach model in Molo and Sisan, the two lowest-coverage districts, with the Provincial Registrar's office, and evaluate it properly. If the effect holds at twelve months, that becomes the case for extending to all eleven districts in Katiba and the evidence base the Civil Registration Technical Advisory Group currently lacks.

Sample two — public finance (298 words)

The Katiba Revenue Authority writes off 21 per cent of assessed small-business tax each year as uncollectable, and the write-offs concentrate in exactly the sectors least able to survive an audit. Having run three compliance pilots, I am convinced this is a design failure rather than an enforcement failure. My priority area is promoting growth and prosperity, since domestic revenue funds everything else we say we want.

I could never say which of those pilots worked, because I had no counterfactual and no way to construct one. The MSc Public Financial Management at Brackenhill University closes that gap. Applied Microeconometrics gives me the identification strategies I lack, and Tax Policy and Administration provides the comparative designs for presumptive regimes that I have been improvising. The policy consultancy term places students with a live public client, and I intend to use mine on small-business compliance rather than a hypothetical case.

I chose Brackenhill for the Institute for Revenue Studies, which advises revenue authorities directly rather than writing about them. Professor Daniel Roux's work on behavioural approaches to compliance in low-capacity administrations addresses our binding constraint, which is enforcement capacity we will never afford. Dr Priya Ramanathan's comparative research on presumptive tax gives me designs I can adapt rather than invent, and her 2025 dataset covers three administrations at our stage.

In my first year back I will run a randomised compliance trial with the Authority's Katiba regional office in the two districts with the highest write-off rates, working with the Small Business Council that already sits on our taxpayer forum. If the design holds, it becomes the evidence base for redesigning the presumptive regime nationally.

Part seven: dos and don'ts

Do

- Name one priority area in Chevening's exact words
- Open with a diagnosis from your own work
- Give national + provincial figure
- Write about first choice only
- Name modules exactly and say what each lets you produce
- Name two academics with positions and reasons
- Finish with a first-year plan (place, partner, action)

Don't

- Mention rankings or reputation
- Describe all three courses
- Copy prospectus text
- Justify by city, culture or English
- Leave module names unchecked
- Promise vague "help my country"

Part eight: checklist

While drafting

- ☐ One priority area, full sentence
- ☐ Diagnosis + national/provincial figures

- ☐ “I cannot currently...” is clear
- ☐ Two or three modules named exactly
- ☐ Two academics with positions and reasons
- ☐ First-year plan with place, partner and action

Before submitting

- ☐ All four live sub-questions visibly answered
- ☐ First-choice course only
- ☐ Module and centre names verified against current handbook
- ☐ Essay fails the university-swap test
- ☐ Problem matches Essays 1 and 2
- ☐ First-year plan is not repeated in Essay 4
- ☐ Within 100–300 words



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